

Tuesday
October 26, 1993

LOCAL

The Charlotte Observer

SECTION C

Classified advertising/5C

Golden eagles stolen from Raptor Center



Carolina Raptor Center

Caesar, a 12-pound male golden eagle stolen...

■ The birds, although missing wings, are wild and would put up a fight, so experienced handlers suspected.

By DAVID PERLMUTT
Staff Writer

Betsy and Caesar are gone.

They are 12-pound golden eagles, mates, parents to one eaglet, and each is missing a wing.

So they couldn't, or wouldn't, have just flown away — even if someone had carelessly left open the cage — from the Carolina Raptor Center, their home of sev-

eral years (Betsy since 1984, Caesar since '87).

Nope, the gate to their cage was securely locked when the center's volunteers left Sunday evening.

So that means that someone sneaked into the center at Latta Plantation Park after dark Sunday, broke the lock — probably with a crowbar — and stole the birds.

"Everyone out here is very attached to these birds, and everyone out here is very angry and very sad that someone would do this," Laura Keistler, the private center's development director, said Monday. "... Whoever took them obviously knew what they were doing. They knew how to handle raptors.

These birds are still wild.

"Even though they are one-winged birds, they would not have hesitated to defend themselves at all costs, with their talons and beaks."

Now the center is left with just one golden eagle, Zlaty. Monday, it appeared the lock to her cage had been tampered, too. Officials promptly moved her to a more secure spot.

Their worst fear is that Betsy and Caesar were taken for their feathers, Keistler said. Certain religious groups use parts of animals for ceremonies, including eagle feathers. Only some Native American Please see **Birds**/page 12C



Carolina Raptor Center

... and Betsy, the female also stolen, bore an eaglet in 1989.

Pair of golden eagles stolen from cage at Raptor Center; rewards offered

Birds

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tribes have a federal license to possess eagle feathers for their ceremonies, she said.

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Department is investigating the theft and is offering up to \$2,500 per bird for information leading to arrests of the birdnappers, Keistler said.

The birds are classified as protected. Stealing them is a federal offense and can bring a \$15,000 fine and a year in prison.

"The fish and wildlife people have enough contacts in the illegal wildlife trade that these people are usually caught, though the animals may not be alive," Keistler said. "If all of a sudden golden eagle feathers start showing up, they'll know something is up."

Golden eagles have yellowish-brown feathers that take on a golden sheen when the sun hits them. They are fierce-looking birds, with long beaks and curled talons the size of your longest finger.

No one knows how old the birds are, though they live to be about 45 years old in the wild. They stand 2 feet tall, and both wings would have spanned six feet. Both came from the western United States, where most golden eagles reside. Betsy came from a rehabilitation center in Arizona, Caesar from one in Utah. Both were probably the victims of gunshot wounds.

They were sent to the Charlotte raptor center to breed. They bore an eaglet in 1989, which was set free in the Georgia mountains. Center officials had planned to try to get the eagles to bear another one this year.

Since they were missing a wing, neither could survive again in the wild. They were supposed to live out their days at the raptor center.

Until they were snatched.

Their cage is about third down

from the center, along a nature trail. They are skittish around people, even caretakers. Most of the time, they nestled in their cage's darkest, back corner. It was rare for them to come to the front.

"We suspect whoever did it specifically picked out their cage and these particular birds," Keistler said. "Someone walking into the park blindly would not have known how to do this."

If only their next-door neigh-

Have information?

Anyone with any information about the stolen birds should call Max Bahos, with the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Department, at (919) 856-4786 from 8 a.m. to 5 p.m., or Mike Loukos, with the N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission, at (919) 892-5355, anytime.

bors, a pair of great horned owls, could talk.

